

HARMONY HILLS COMMUNITY GARDEN
Operations Manual & Garden Guidelines
Established 2018 | 3.5 Acres | 120 Plot Members

Garden Manager: Patricia "Patty" Green
Location: 456 Meadowbrook Lane, Riverside
Season: March through November

MISSION STATEMENT

Harmony Hills Community Garden provides residents with space to grow fresh, organic produce while fostering community connections, promoting sustainable gardening practices, and educating future generations about food cultivation and environmental stewardship.

PLOT INFORMATION

Total Plots: 120 individual plots + 8 communal plots

Individual Plot Size: 10ft x 10ft (100 sq ft)

Plot Types:

- Standard Ground Plots: 100 plots (\$50/season)
- Raised Bed Plots: 20 plots (\$75/season - includes bed construction)
- Communal Plots: 8 plots (no fee, harvest shared among volunteers)

Plot Assignment:

Assignments made via lottery system each February. Waitlist typically 3-4 months. Priority given to returning gardeners in good standing.

Plot Fees Due: March 1st

Late Payment: \$10 fee after March 15th

Payment Methods: Check, cash, Venmo (@HarmonyHillsGarden)

GARDEN RULES & REGULATIONS

1. GROWING GUIDELINES

- Organic methods only (no chemical pesticides or herbicides)
- Approved organic fertilizers: compost, fish emulsion, bone meal
- Plant only edible plants, flowers, and herbs in your plot
- No invasive species (see restricted plant list)
- Maintain pathways around your plot (keep clear, 2ft minimum)

2. WATERING

- Water sources: 4 spigots located at corners of garden
- Watering hours: 6 AM - 9 PM daily
- Bring your own hose or watering can
- Soaker hoses and drip irrigation encouraged
- No sprinklers that spray onto neighboring plots

3. MAINTENANCE REQUIREMENTS

- Keep your plot weed-free and well-maintained
- Remove dead plants promptly
- No plants over 6 feet tall without approval
- Support structures (trellises, stakes) must be sturdy
- Clean up by November 30th each year

4. SHARED SPACES

- Tool shed: Available 8 AM - 7 PM, return tools after use
- Compost bins: Kitchen scraps and garden waste only (no meat/dairy)

- Picnic area: Clean up after use, no glass containers
- Children's garden: Supervised children welcome

5. PROHIBITED ITEMS

- Chemical pesticides and herbicides
- Invasive plant species
- Glass containers or sharp objects left unattended
- Structures attached to fence
- Political signs or commercial advertising

COMMUNAL TOOLS & RESOURCES

Tool Shed Inventory:

- 6 shovels (various sizes)
- 8 rakes (leaf and garden)
- 12 hand trowels
- 6 hoes
- 4 wheelbarrows
- 2 garden carts
- Various hand tools (pruners, weeders, cultivators)
- 8 watering cans
- 2 soil pH test kits
- 1 broadcast spreader

Borrowing Policy:

Sign out tools on clipboard in shed. Return same day. If tool breaks, report to Patty immediately. Replacement cost charged for lost tools.

Seed Library:

Located in tool shed. Donate extra seeds. Take what you need.
Most popular varieties: tomatoes, peppers, squash, herbs.

Reference Materials:

- Planting calendar (posted on bulletin board)
- Companion planting guide
- Pest identification chart
- Local extension office guides

PLANTING CALENDAR (Zone 7)

EARLY SPRING (March-April):

Cold-Hardy Crops:

- Lettuce, spinach, arugula (direct sow March 15)
- Peas (sow March 20)
- Radishes, carrots (sow April 1)
- Broccoli, cauliflower (transplant April 10)
- Onion sets (plant April 1)

LATE SPRING (May):

After Last Frost (May 10):

- Tomatoes (transplant May 15)
- Peppers (transplant May 15)
- Squash, cucumbers (direct sow May 20)
- Beans (sow May 25)
- Basil, cilantro (transplant May 15)

SUMMER (June-July):

Succession Planting:

- Beans (sow every 2 weeks until July 15)
- Lettuce (in shaded areas, until June 30)

- Cucumbers (second planting July 1)

LATE SUMMER (August):

Fall Crops:

- Kale, collards (transplant Aug 1)
- Lettuce, spinach (sow Aug 15)
- Radishes (sow Aug 20)
- Garlic cloves (plant October 15)

BEST PERFORMING VARIETIES (Based on member feedback)

TOMATOES:

- Cherokee Purple (heirloom, great flavor)
- Sungold cherry (heavy producer, sweet)
- San Marzano (paste, excellent for sauce)

Average yield: 15-25 lbs per plant

PEPPERS:

- California Wonder bell (reliable, large fruit)
- Jalapeño (consistent producer)
- Shishito (easy to grow, mild heat)

Average yield: 8-12 peppers per plant

SQUASH:

- Zucchini (Black Beauty variety)
- Yellow Crookneck
- Butternut (for fall harvest)

Note: One plant is usually sufficient - very productive!

BEANS:

- Blue Lake bush beans (easy, no support needed)
- Kentucky Wonder pole beans (climbers, heavy yield)

Average yield: 5 lbs per 10ft row

HERBS:

- Basil (Genovese for pesto)
- Cilantro (slow-bolt variety for summer)
- Parsley (Italian flat-leaf)
- Mint (plant in container - spreads aggressively!)

PEST MANAGEMENT (Organic Methods)

COMMON PESTS & SOLUTIONS:

Aphids:

- Spray with water to dislodge
- Neem oil solution (1 tbsp per gallon water)
- Attract ladybugs (natural predators)

Tomato Hornworms:

- Hand-pick (large, green caterpillars)
- Encourage natural predators (wasps)
- Plant dill and marigolds nearby

Cucumber Beetles:

- Yellow sticky traps
- Row covers for young plants
- Diatomaceous earth around base

Slugs:

- Beer traps (shallow containers sunk in soil)
- Copper tape around beds
- Hand-pick at night

Squash Vine Borers:

- Row covers until flowering
- Wrap base of stems with aluminum foil
- Check regularly for entry holes

BENEFICIAL INSECTS TO ATTRACT:

- Ladybugs (eat aphids) - plant dill, fennel
 - Lacewings (eat aphids) - plant cosmos, yarrow
 - Ground beetles (eat slugs) - provide mulch hiding spots
 - Bees (pollination) - plant flowers: sunflowers, zinnias
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COMPOSTING GUIDELINES

Three-Bin System:

Bin 1: Fresh materials (current season)

Bin 2: Decomposing (from last season)

Bin 3: Finished compost (ready to use)

GREEN MATERIALS (Nitrogen-rich):

- ✓ Vegetable and fruit scraps
- ✓ Coffee grounds and tea bags
- ✓ Fresh grass clippings
- ✓ Green plant material

BROWN MATERIALS (Carbon-rich):

- ✓ Dried leaves
- ✓ Straw or hay
- ✓ Shredded paper (unbleached)
- ✓ Cardboard (small pieces)

DO NOT COMPOST:

- x Meat, fish, dairy products
- x Oils or fats
- x Pet waste
- x Diseased plant material
- x Weeds with seeds

Proper Ratio: 3 parts brown to 1 part green

Turn pile every 2 weeks for faster decomposition

Ready compost: Dark, crumbly, earthy smell (4-6 months)

WATER CONSERVATION TIPS

Mulching:

Apply 2-3 inches of organic mulch around plants. Best materials:

- Straw (not hay - has seeds)
- Shredded leaves
- Grass clippings (thin layer, dried)

Benefits: Retains moisture, suppresses weeds, moderates soil temperature

Drip Irrigation:

- 50% more efficient than overhead watering
- Delivers water directly to roots
- Reduces disease by keeping foliage dry

Garden provides free drip tape to members (ask Patty)

Watering Best Practices:

- Water deeply (1 inch per week) rather than frequent shallow watering
- Water early morning (reduces evaporation, prevents fungal diseases)
- Check soil moisture before watering (finger test - dry 2 inches down)
- Tomatoes need consistent water (prevents blossom end rot)
- Reduce watering as crops near maturity

Rain Barrels:

Four 50-gallon rain barrels positioned around garden. First-come basis. Use for supplemental watering during dry spells.

COMMUNITY EVENTS & ACTIVITIES

SPRING KICKOFF - First Saturday in April

- Plot assignments finalized
- Seed swap
- Gardening workshop
- Light refreshments

Time: 10 AM - 12 PM

MONTHLY WORKSHOPS - Second Saturday, 9 AM

April: Soil Preparation & Composting

May: Transplanting & Succession Planting

June: Pest Management (Organic Methods)

July: Harvesting & Food Preservation

August: Fall Gardening

September: Seed Saving

SUMMER POTLUCK - Mid-July

- Bring dish made with garden produce
- Recipe exchange
- Garden tours
- Kids activities

Time: 5 PM - 8 PM

HARVEST FESTIVAL - First Saturday in October

- Pumpkin decorating contest
- Garden produce competition (biggest tomato, etc.)
- Fall baking contest
- Cleanup day

Time: 2 PM - 6 PM

CHILDREN'S PROGRAMS:

"Little Sprouts" Garden Club - Ages 5-10

Meets Saturdays in June, 10 AM - 11 AM

Activities: Planting, bug hunts, garden crafts

Coordinator: Linda Martinez, 555-0167

VOLUNTEER OPPORTUNITIES

Garden Council (Elected annually in February):

- President: Oversees operations, leads meetings
- Treasurer: Manages budget, collects fees
- Secretary: Takes meeting notes, communications
- Plot Coordinator: Manages assignments, waitlist

Current Council:

President: Marcus Johnson

Treasurer: Diane Foster

Secretary: Roberto Mendez

Plot Coordinator: Patty Green (also Garden Manager)

Volunteer Positions:

- Watering Coordinator: Monitors during heat waves
- Tool Maintenance: Keeps tools sharp and functional
- Compost Captain: Manages bins, educates members
- Social Media: Posts updates, photos (Instagram @HarmonyHillsGarden)

Workdays:

Third Saturday monthly, 9 AM - 12 PM

Tasks: Path maintenance, weeding communal areas, repairs

Pizza provided for volunteers!

EDUCATIONAL RESOURCES

Recommended Reading:

- "The Vegetable Gardener's Bible" by Edward C. Smith
- "Square Foot Gardening" by Mel Bartholomew
- "Rodale's Basic Organic Gardening" by Deborah L. Martin

Online Resources:

- Local extension office: www.extension.state.edu
- USDA planting zones: planthardiness.ars.usda.gov
- Companion planting: www.almanac.com/companion-planting-guide

Expert Consultations:

Master Gardener visits second Saturday each month (May-September)

Free advice, plant diagnosis, questions answered

Library:

Small lending library in tool shed. Borrow books, return when finished.

HARVEST DONATION PROGRAM

Partnership with Local Food Bank:

Communal plots designated for donation. All produce from these plots goes to Riverside Community Food Bank.

2024 Donations: 847 lbs of fresh produce

Goal for 2025: 1,000 lbs

Members encouraged to donate surplus:

Drop-off box near tool shed (checked daily by volunteers)

Last season top donors:

1. Chen Family Plot - 127 lbs
2. Rodriguez Plot - 94 lbs
3. Miller/Smith Plot - 78 lbs

CONTACT INFORMATION

Garden Manager: Patricia "Patty" Green

Phone: 555-0142

Email: patty@harmonyhillsgarden.org

Mailing Address:

Harmony Hills Community Garden

c/o Riverside Parks Department

789 City Hall Drive

Riverside, State 12345

Website: www.harmonyhillsgarden.org
Facebook: Harmony Hills Community Garden
Instagram: @HarmonyHillsGarden

Emergency Contact (after hours):
Riverside Parks Department: 555-0180

Plot Waitlist Information:
Email waitlist@harmonyhillsgarden.org
Current wait time: 3-4 months
Applications open year-round

GARDEN POLICIES

Plot Abandonment:
If plot is neglected for 3+ weeks without communication, Garden Manager will attempt contact. If no response within 1 week, plot may be reassigned. No refund given.

Guest Policy:
Members may bring guests. Members responsible for guests' behavior and compliance with rules. Children must be supervised.

Photography:
Members may photograph their own plots. Ask permission before photographing others or their plots.

Parking:
Street parking only. Do not block driveways. Bicycle racks available at entrance.

Dogs:
Must be leashed at all times. Clean up after pets immediately. Dogs not allowed in garden beds or communal areas.

END OF MANUAL

Last Updated: December 2024
Next Review: February 2025

For questions or concerns, contact Patty Green at 555-0142

Happy Gardening! 🌱🍅🥕